the crowd shouting and cheering during the game. It was an amazing feeling. *Forty minutes, an hour ago, this place was full of people. We were playing out there. We were getting beaten out there*.

And then I looked down at the trophy, which I'd set on the grass in front of me. It made me shiver. For a moment, I felt like the thirteen-year-old boy who'd jogged out onto this same field for the first time, nervous about meeting FC Barcelona's star players and trying to imagine what it would be like to play at their ground. I picked up the European Cup and the photographer snapped away. One of the proudest moments any player could ever experience in his career and I found myself standing there, in the half light with a winners' medal hanging round my neck, feeling humble in the face of what had just taken place. I got the same sensation later that evening, when the players walked into the hotel room for dinner. Victoria was there, my mum and dad too, along with all the families and closest friends. Everyone stood up at their tables and clapped.

I hung onto that trophy. I thought I could make it my job to get it safely out of the ground. I walked out into the parking lot to look for the coach. Everyone else seemed to have drifted away and there was this eerie quiet in the air. The one or two voices you could hear sounded like they were coming from miles away. I looked up and saw Dad walking towards me. He just appeared out of the gloom, from nowhere, walking along with Mum and some other people. It wasn't as if we'd arranged to meet straight after the game: I'd been expecting to see them back at the hotel. Ninety thousand people inside the Nou Camp that night and your mum and dad are the ones you bump into by chance. We were the only people there.

Dad didn't need to say a word. He hugged me. It felt like he was crying or, at least, trying hard not to. And my eyes were tearing up too. The two of us knew what it had been like when we'd met less than a year before, in another parking lot, after the Argentina game in Saint-Etienne. My parents knew better than anybody what had happened to me since that night. It had happened to them, too, in a way. That's how it is with your children. Their lives become the most important part of your own. I knew what it felt like to be a father now, of course. So I put down the cup and just hugged my dad back.